Building Rapport with Customers

Starting confident conversations that build trust



Agent Rapport Job Aid



Building Rapport: Job Aid Overview

Why rapport matters

Early trust and respect reduce tension and help customers explain needs clearly—even when issues are complex.

What this job aid teaches

Practical, flexible techniques for how you sound, what you say, and how you respond—across calls, chat, and in person.

Outcomes and when to use it

Improves satisfaction and first-contact resolution; use before shifts, during coaching, and for onboarding new agents.

What Rapport Means

A trusting, respectful connection

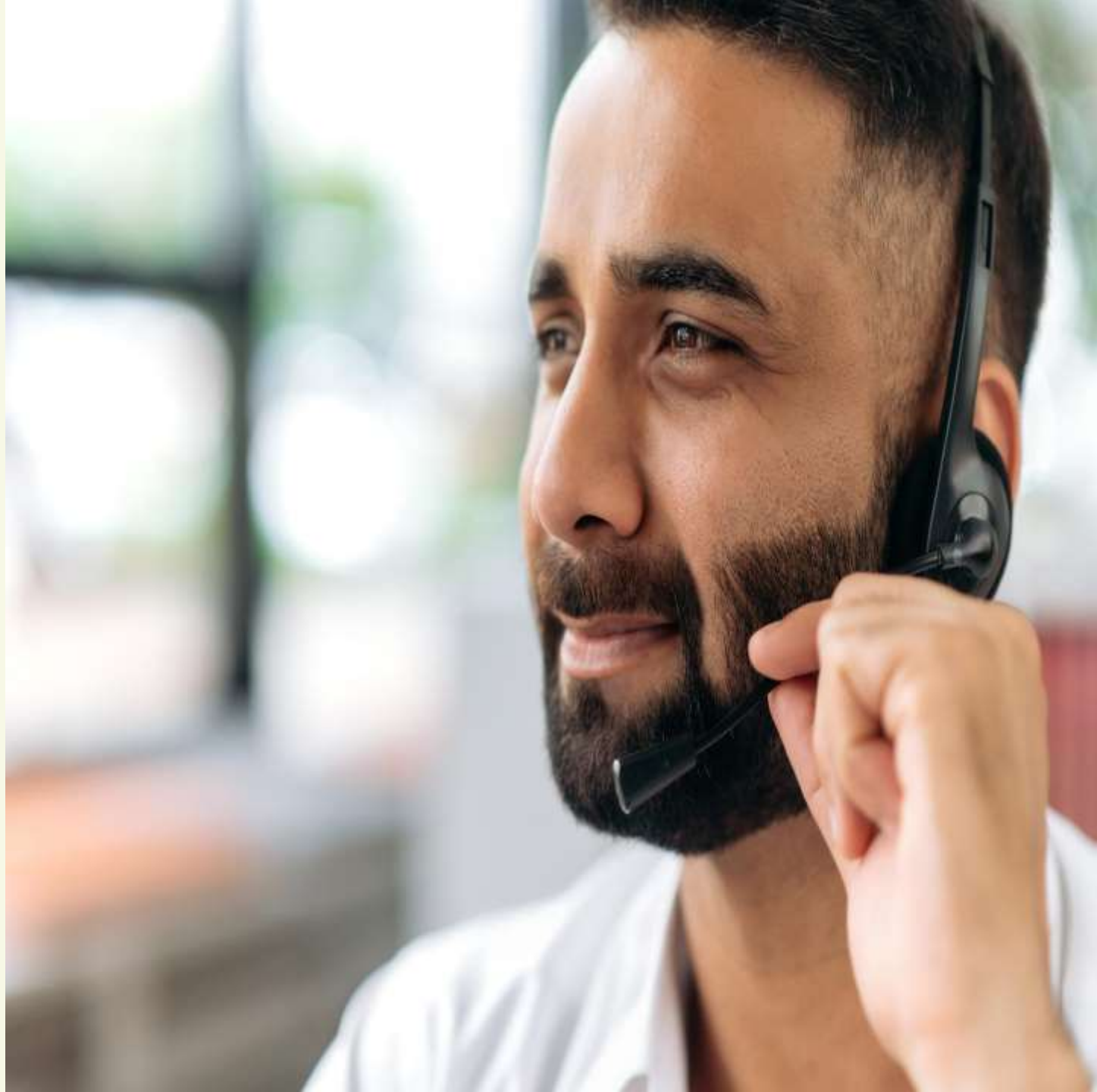
More than politeness—customers feel heard, valued, and understood, making them more willing to share details and follow guidance.

Built in the first seconds

Tone, pace, word choice, and attentiveness shape trust early; calm and friendly delivery lowers anxiety, while rushed language creates distance.

Practical habits (professional, not familiar)

Acknowledge emotions, use the customer's name appropriately, match their style, and listen without interrupting—especially during complaints or escalations.





Build Rapport Quickly

Start strong

Use a warm, professional greeting; introduce yourself; use the customer’s name naturally.

Match and listen

Mirror tone and pace; let them finish; acknowledge and summarize to confirm understanding.

Empathize and stay positive

Acknowledge feelings and use “what we can do” language to build trust and move to resolution.

Effective Ways to Start the Customer Conversation

Open with clarity and warmth

Greet politely, sound confident, and offer help right away so the customer knows they reached the right place.

Listen fully before solving

Let the customer explain without interruption; it shows respect and prevents repeated explanations later.

Confirm and clarify together

Restate the issue, ask open-ended questions, and reassure: “I can help with that” and “Let’s take care of this together.”



Rapport-Building Statement Examples

Validate emotions

“I completely understand how that can be frustrating.”

Reassure and partner

“No worries – I’m here to help you.”
“Thank you for your patience, I appreciate it.”

Show ownership and confidence

“Let me take care of that for you.”
Use naturally; avoid over-repetition.



Common Mistakes That Damage Rapport

Sounding scripted or interrupting

A robotic tone or cutting customers off makes the interaction feel rushed and impersonal.

Negative language and jargon

Focusing on limitations or using internal terms can escalate frustration and create confusion.

Missing emotions and rushing

Not acknowledging feelings—or moving too fast—reduces trust even when the fix is correct.



Practical Tips to Maintain Rapport

Set the right tone

Smile while speaking, use clear language, and keep a steady pace—warm, calm, and never rushed.

Stay composed and solution-focused

Maintain emotional control when customers are upset, and steer the conversation toward next steps and fixes.

Confirm understanding and close positively

Check for understanding, take brief notes to personalize, then confirm resolution and thank the customer.

